patronage of a variety of Jain donors from Madurai, mostly merchants with specific trades ranging from goldsmiths to salt-traders, including a nun and a local prince. Here was striking evidence of wide-ranging support for the Jain religion in the South in the first centuries of the Common Era.

From Alagarmalai, Mahadevan and his team moved north to the Mankulam caves, where Robert Sewell had first reported the existence of inscriptions back in 1882. ‘The bright winter sun had lit up the façade of the upper southern cave and the long one-line inscription on the brow of the boulder caught my eye,’ he was afterwards to write:

> It was weather-worn and looked more like bruising on the rock than engraving, but was otherwise undamaged. The bold and legible letters were clearly visible to the naked eye. As I spelled out *ne-tu-n-ca-li-ya-n* and *va-lu-ti-y* I realised with astonishment that I was indeed looking at an inscription of the Pantiyan [Pandyan] king of the Cankan [Sangam] Age not reported earlier … During the same visit, I discovered that the name *netincaliyan* also occurs in the long inscription in the lower cave on the site. It is strange but true that the incorrect reading of a single letter by Krishna Sastri and Subrahmanya Aiyer resulted in their failure to recognise the famous name and the historical significance of the record.